RemoteDig

Run an excavator from your living room. Operators anywhere, machines everywhere.

What It Is

RemoteDig is a teleoperation service that lets trained operators run excavators and heavy machinery from thousands of miles away, using cameras, sensors, and a remote console connected over 4G, 5G, wifi, or Starlink. No dirty job sites, no operators stuck in cabs for hours — just a screen and controls. It's not a new excavator; it's a new place from which the work happens, opening construction labor to anyone with the skill and a connection.

How It Makes Money

You sell remote-operation capacity to contractors and site owners — either as a service (operators-for-hire running their machines remotely) or by retrofitting client excavators with the teleop kit and charging setup plus a per-hour/subscription fee. Buyers are construction firms facing operator shortages, dangerous or remote sites (mining, demolition, disaster zones), and companies wanting to keep skilled operators working across multiple job sites in a day.

Startup Costs

- Teleoperation retrofit kit (cameras, sensors, controllers, comms): $8,000-$30,000 per machine
- Operator control station (multi-screen rig + console): $3,000-$10,000
- Connectivity (5G modems + Starlink units): $1,000-$3,000
- Low-latency software/integration + engineering: $5,000-$25,000
- Insurance and safety certification: $3,000-$15,000/year
- Pilot/demo machine access or partnership: variable
- Site marketing + B2B sales: $1,000-$5,000
- **Realistic start: $20,000-$80,000+** (this is a capital-heavy, high-ceiling play; start with one machine and one contractor partner)

Sourcing: Source components from Alibaba/industrial suppliers — search "industrial remote control console," "excavator teleoperation retrofit kit," "low latency video transmitter 5G," and "ruggedized PTZ camera." Many builders assemble from off-the-shelf cameras, controllers, and edge-compute units.

The Numbers

- Retrofit + station cost per operational machine: ~$15,000-$45,000
- Charge: $90-$180/hr for remote operation, or $2,000-$6,000/month retrofit subscription per machine
- A single machine at 120 billable hours/month at $120/hr = ~$14,400 revenue; net after operator pay and overhead ~$6,000-$9,000/month
- Payback on one retrofitted machine: ~4-8 months
- Scales by adding machines and letting one operator cover multiple sites per day.

How To Start

1. Build or buy one teleoperation kit and a control station; prove safe, low-latency control on a test machine.

2. Partner with one contractor who has idle machines or an operator shortage for a paid pilot.
3. Nail safety protocols, fail-safes, and insurance — this is the gate that wins or loses contracts.
4. Document a real job done remotely (video + metrics) as your sales proof.
5. Price as service-hours or a per-machine retrofit subscription.
6. Sell to construction, mining, and demolition firms hit hardest by labor shortages.
7. Reinvest into more kits and a roster of remote operators covering multiple sites.

Where To Get Customers

- Direct B2B sales to construction, mining, demolition, and infrastructure firms
- Industry trade shows and construction-tech expos
- LinkedIn outreach to operations and site managers
- Partnerships with equipment rental yards and dealers
- Government/disaster-response and hazardous-site contracts

Pro Tips

- Lead with the operator-shortage and safety angle (no one in the cab in dangerous zones) — that's what unlocks budget, not the tech novelty.
- Start by retrofitting clients' existing machines rather than owning fleets; you scale on their capital, not yours.
- Latency and a bulletproof fail-safe are everything — over-invest there, because one runaway machine ends the business.
